GED 3402 Music in Western Civilization

8.2: ***German Opera***
&
***Richard Wagner*华格纳** 1813-1883

composer, librettist, poet, theatre director, polemicist

Prof. Chan Wing Wah

Opera from Italy to Germany

Though opera was invented by the Italians, other countries immediately adopted this art form in particularly France and Germany.

- German operas with *spoken dialogue* began to flourish in the Romantic Period.
- The use of orchestra was more extended that Wagner invented his Wagner tuba.
- The plot is more on legends and folk heroes.
- The pursuit of inner feelings and expressions to philosophical issues.

Mozart's *German Singspiel* (opera with spoken dialogue)

- *Die Entführung aus dem Serail* 后宫缘, '***The Abduction from the Seraglio***' *K.384, 1782*
  librettist Gottlieb Stephanie, based on Christoph Friedrich Bretzner's Belmont und Constanze. Full opera: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=V5lLp4KdDzs

- ***Die Zauberflöte, The Magic Flute,***魔笛 *K.620, 1791, a 2-Act opera*
- Close collaboration with librettist Emanuel Schikaneder who drew elements from many sources. Full opera: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=02u4Jf_aNPI
- *Pa-pa-pa Papageno* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qF0lidudY74
- *Queen of the Night aria* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YuBeBjqKSGQ coloratura 花腔女高音

Carl Maria von Weber 1786-1826

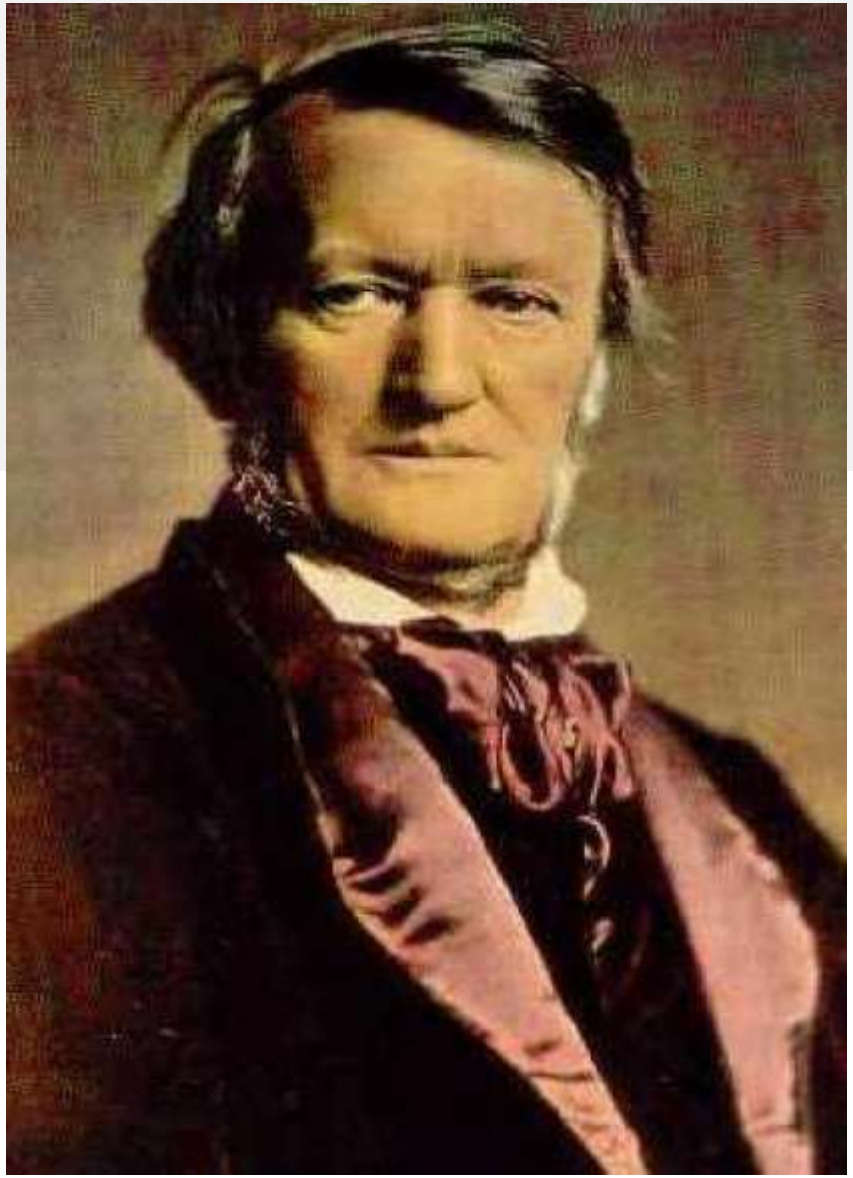
- ***Der Freischütz, (The Freeshooter)*** *魔弹射手*Op.77, 1821
- A 3-Act opera
- Hamburg State Opera, 1968 film, with English surtitles
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G8GFvzxLq4Y Overture finishes at 9', chorus begins, English surtitles

Richard Wagner 1813-1883

composer, conductor, polemicist, theatre director, librettist, playwright

- *Gesamtkunstwerk complete art work* : had written numerous essays to express his views on synthesizing the poetic, visual, musical and dramatic arts, with music subsidiary to drama.
- His operas feature *complex textures*, *rich harmony and colourful orchestration*. He had also written an autobiography and wrote his first play at 14 years old.
- First two operas not successful.
- Using a period of 26 years to compose *Der Ring (The Ring)*指环,
- *a cycle of 4 operas* .
- Travelled among London, Paris, Zürich and the German cities.
- Ludwig II, King of Bayern became his patron in later years and built a theatre for him.

Wagner



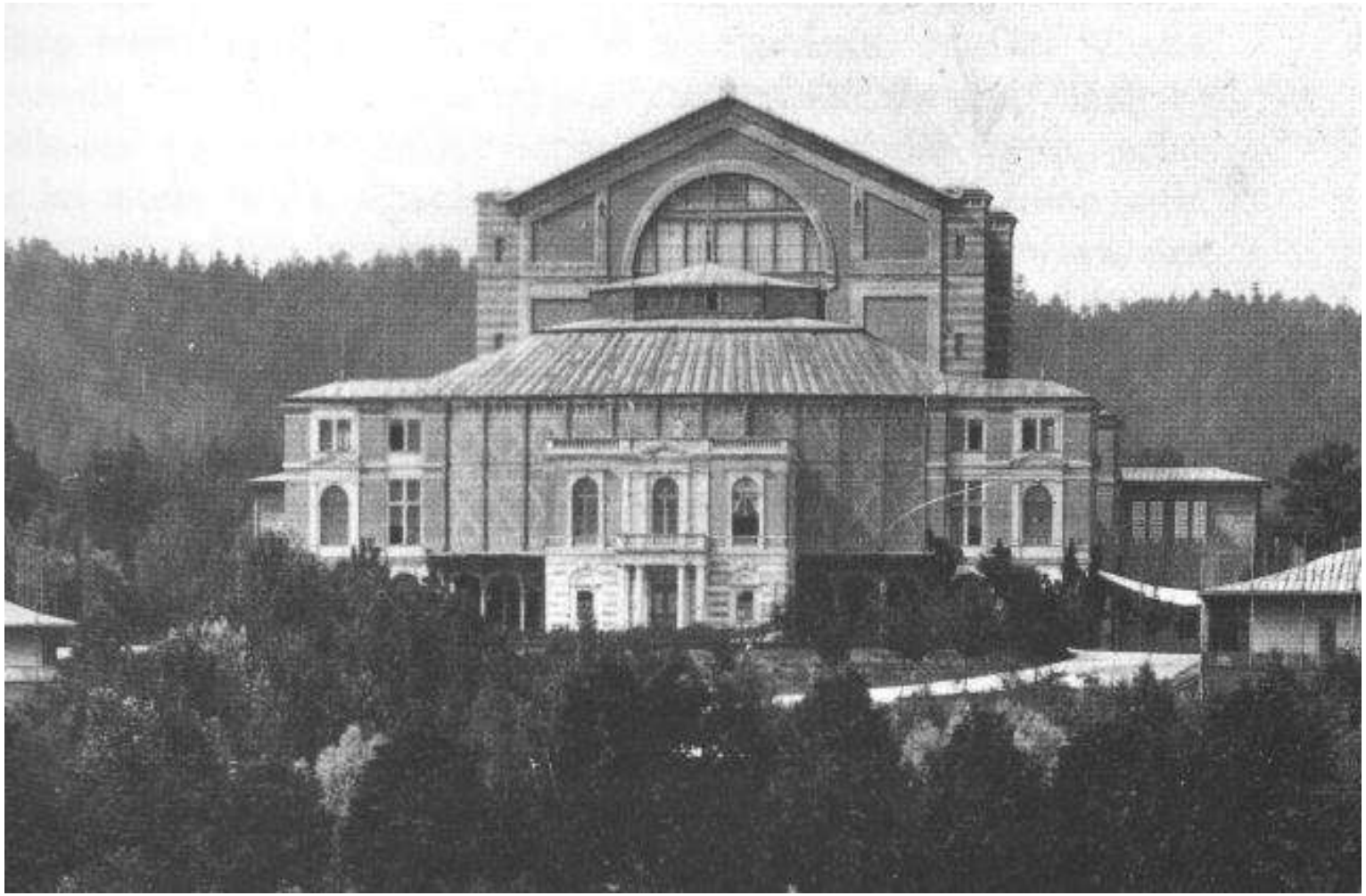
- Ludwig II



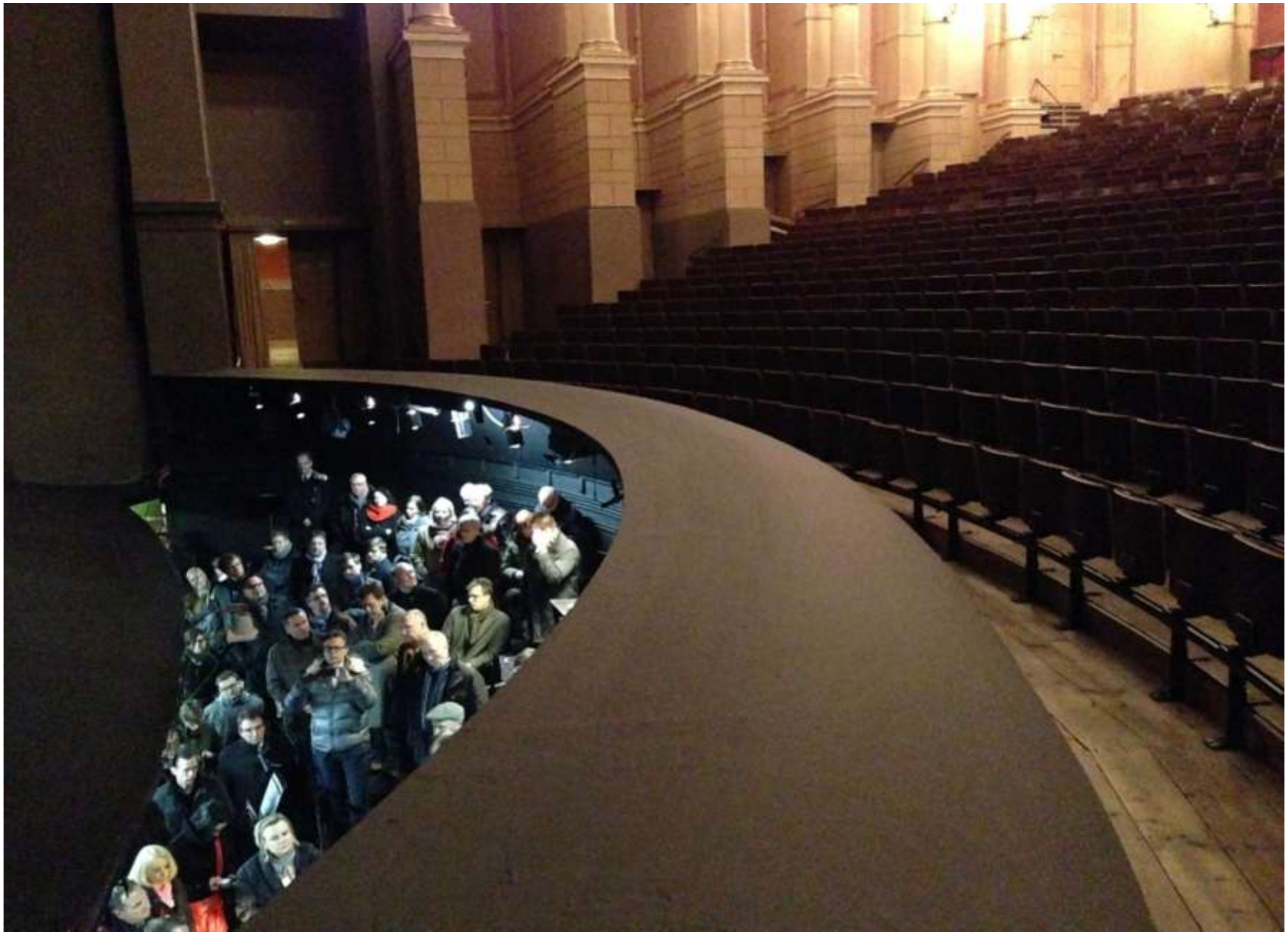
Richard Wagner https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Richard_Wagner

- *Bayreuth Festspielhaus* or Bayreuth Festival Theatre, *Richard-Wagner-Festspielhaus*.
- Bayreuth Festivalhttps://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bayreuth_Festival
- Patron : Ludwig II, King of Bayern 1864-1886

Bayreuth Festspielhaus







Wagner wrote 13 operas : Music & Libretto

- ***Die Feen*** *The Fairies*1834, unperformed in his life time,
- ***Lebesverbot*** *The Ban on Love* 1836 (1836) withdrawn after premiere

- ***Rienzi*** 1840 (1842) Italian populist Rienzi (1313-54) against the nobles
- ***Der fliegende Holländer*** *The Flying Dutchman* 飄泊的荷蘭人。1841 (1843). Heine retold a 17th century legend of a ghost captain with a ship that will never port. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ezqen5-UxlQ
- Horns and trombones to start the Overture.

- ***Tannhäuser***唐怀瑟 1845 (1845). Medieval German Minnesänger
- Overture https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o-NI4WixVUg Berliner Philharmoniker. Karayan

- Listen to the building up from winds to eventually brass with strings actively as background
- Grand March https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mT5Igmv8eow

*Lohengrin*罗恩格林 1847 (1850). Swan Knight the Medieval Crusade

Bridal Chorus https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=J2lX86w-pT4 from 3’49



***Der Ring des Nibelungen* (*The Ring of the Nibelung*)**

尼贝龙根的指环1848-74

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Der_Ring_des_Nibelungen

- *1. Das Rheingold*莱恩河的黄金(*The Rhinegold*)
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Cy35DQqGxQ4 stage on water
- *2. Die Walküre*女武神(*The Valkyrie*)：*Act III. The Ride of the Valkyrie*
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TAEQMp4soOw Met
  - Apocalyse Now (1979) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nZ_zNUmr8fM
- *3. Siegfried* 齐格非
- *4. Götterdämmerung* (*The Twilight of the Gods*) 诸神的黄昏

Tristan und Isolde.崔斯坦1859 (1865). 12th century German romance

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tristan_und_Isolde

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fktwPGCR7Yw Zubin Mehta

Die Meistersinger von Nürnberg. *The Mastersingers of Nuremberg*.

纽伦堡的歌手

Around 4.5 hours to perform, the longest single opera so far.

- Medieval story in Germany on legendary Meistersinger Hans Sachs 1494-1576. Walther and Eva, Beckmesser.

Opera https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2KRj8GKGocs Bayreuth, chorus begins at 14'47"

Prelude in Concert version https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZVO5s9zAqAQ Thielemann. Schloss Hiemsee

Beckmesser https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=m4qs8bFZORw

Die Meistersinger von Nürnberg

The Mastersingers of Nuremberg

- Walther's Love Song
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-415xy5zT7s English surtitle
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NrjnelUsbZI
- Shining in the rosy light of morning,
  the air heavy
  with blossom and scent,
  full of every
  unthought-of joy,
  a garden invited me
  to be its guest".

  Morgenlich leuchtend in rosigem Schein,
  von Blüt und Duft
  geschwellt die Luft,
  voll aller Wonnen,
  nie ersonnen,
  ein Garten lud mich ein,
  Gast ihm zu sein".

- Scene of Finale https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=u61XvPYyaE0
- Listen to all the motifs in the Prelude come back with new singing lines on top.

Wagner and Schopenhauer 叔本华

- In 1854, Wagner first read Schopenhauer's (1788-1860) theories on aesthetics. In this philosophy, art is a means for escaping from the sufferings of the world, and music is the highest of the arts and the only one not involved in representation of the world (i.e. it is *abstract*). It is for this reason that music can communicate emotion without the need for words.

Wagner Operas and Neuschwanstein Castle

New Swan Stone Castle



Linderhof Grotto



Wagner's Influence in Film Music

- Two articles:

- https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-2010-jun-17-la-et-wagner-movies-20100617-story.html

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_films_using_the_music_of_Richard_Wagner

German opera versus Italian opera:

- **German operas** usually have more complicated plots and music. The stories are mostly German folklore and legend. The orchestra size is generally very big thus requiring a very loud and projecting sound from the singers such as the Heldentenor (heroic tenor)
- Wagner's operas are always studied by psychologists and psychiatrists.

- The general atmosphere of **Italian operas** is distinctively different from that of the German operas. Italian operas are more light-hearted featuring mainly one or two pairs of characters with a simpler plot of love story. German operas are generally darker in tone with psychological and mythical elements. At times it also consists of spoken dialogue. German operas usually call for a large size orchestra.

How Western Opera Came to China?

- https://www.artsjournal.com/china/2014/06/how-western-opera-came-to-china/

- Wu Promotion 吴氏策划 bringing Chinese orchestras, Chinese opera groups to Vienna; bringing Austro-German groups to China including the *Ring Opera Cycle*.
- Founded in Beijing in 1991 by
- 1. Wu Zezhou 吴泽洲 1937-2021
- Beijing Normal University teaching cryogenics 低温物理, research in Walther-Meissner-Institute Munich.
- 2. and son Wu Jiatong 吴嘉童
- Studied German language in Munich, and Electronic Engineering (Automation System) in Vienna University of Technology.